to swallow me whole. That was a long walk back, to sympathetic applause I didn't merit. I had failed a basic test, in being controlled by the environment.

Is it any wonder superstition is rife in cricket, when failure can be so infuriating? I've lost count of the number of times I have sat on a dressing-room chair and wasn't allowed to move. If someone does so, and someone gets out, you're like, 'Urghh … what?' It is almost a betrayal. Some people, including Trotty, Jimmy and Graeme Swann, used to just lie there.

Swanny wouldn't watch many balls live. He'd be on his back, in front of the TV. My kit used to be an organized mess, Trotty's was immaculately laid out, like a still-life painting, but Swanny's was a public health hazard. He had his lucky pink shorts, which were white until something leaked colour in the wash, and bowled in the same cycling shorts for days on end.

The undercurrent of such eccentricity is the inherent seriousness of Test cricket. I spoke in the previous chapter of my opening partners. Some had a technical fault, exacerbated by a perceived inability to adapt under scrutiny. Did that mean they weren't quite good enough at that stage in their careers, and should have been allowed to incubate in county cricket? Did they get a raw deal?

It's debatable. But one thing that cannot be challenged is the scorebook. When you strip away the extraneous stuff, the noise and the political posturing, if you are scoring a lot of runs you won't be dropped. Some people who feel hard done by look for the excuse that they weren't treated properly, or given enough opportunity.

Sorry, but if they had scored four centuries in their seven or eight matches, they would have played more. I realize that sounds dispassionate, callous even, but that is the harsh reality of professional sport. Produce with occasionally undue haste or repent at your leisure. The cut-throat nature of Test cricket is what makes it so hard, so intense, and ultimately so rewarding.

There can be anomalies. James Taylor, for instance, spent a long time outside the England set-up because Andy Flower and the selectors came to a certain view on him. It was nothing personal and didn't reflect badly on Andy, but it took a long time for them to be convinced James had the skillset required to progress from being a prolific county cricketer.

A teenage prodigy at Leicestershire, some had deemed him too small, though he was taller than Sachin Tendulkar. In technical terms, he had a